

Romanesque art

Following the collapse of the Roman Empire in Italy in the fifth century CE, western Europe experienced a long period of turmoil. The Roman Catholic Church was the only unifying force, and monasteries, especially the new Cistercian and Cluniac orders that developed in France, needed new buildings, books and Bibles. Large churches were built to accommodate priests and monks, and to welcome pilgrims who came to view saints' relics. Statues, reliefs, stained glass windows and wall paintings portrayed Christian doctrine to instruct illiterate churchgoers.

Romanesque art refers to a fusion of Roman, Carolingian, Ottonian, Byzantine and local Germanic elements, generally on a grander scale and more flamboyant than Early Christian art. Roman architectural features in its churches included rounded arches, barrel vaults and apses. This was one of the first times that individual artists and architects became known and sought after. The style peaked between 1075 and 1125, predominantly in France, Italy, Britain and the German lands.



Figures on the portico of the Cathedral of Santiago de Compostela, Spain, c.1180